A FREE GUIDE FOR BUYERS

THE KNOXVILLE HOME BUYER'S GUIDE

Everything you need to know, from your first search to the day you get the keys, in plain language.

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WELCOME

YOUR PATH TO THE KEYS

Buying a home is exciting, and it can also feel like a lot. This guide walks you through the process in the order it actually happens, so you always know what comes next and what to ask. Every buyer's situation is different, so use this as your roadmap and lean on me for the details.

01
GET CLEAR
Define your must-haves, your nice-to-haves and your timeline.

02
GET PRE-APPROVED
Know your numbers before you fall in love with a home.

03
SET YOUR BUDGET
Look past the price to the true monthly cost.

04
CHOOSE YOUR AGENT
Sign a buyer agreement so we can work together with clarity.

05
SEARCH & TOUR
See homes in person and compare what matters most.

06
MAKE AN OFFER
Price, terms and timing, written to give you the best shot.

07
INSPECT & APPRAISE
Verify the condition and value before you commit.

08
CLOSE & MOVE IN
Final walkthrough, signing, and keys in hand.

HOW LONG DOES IT TAKE?
Most buyers spend a few weeks to a few months searching, then roughly 30 to 45 days from accepted offer to closing. Starting with pre-approval keeps everything moving.

BEFORE YOU START SEARCHING

1 · GET CLEAR ON WHAT YOU WANT

Write down your top three must-haves (bedrooms, commute, school zone, yard) and a short list of nice-to-haves. Decide how soon you want to move. Being specific saves time and helps me find the right homes first.

2 · GET PRE-APPROVED

A lender reviews your income, credit and assets and tells you how much you can borrow. Sellers take pre-approved buyers seriously, and you'll know your real budget. Ask about:

- Loan types: conventional, FHA, VA and USDA each have different down payment and credit rules.
- Down payment options. You don't always need 20% down.
- State and local assistance programs. Ask me or your lender about programs from the Tennessee Housing Development Agency (THDA).

WHAT LENDERS USUALLY ASK FOR

- Recent pay stubs
- Recent bank statements
- List of debts and monthly payments
- Two years of tax returns / W-2s
- Photo ID
- Gift or asset documentation, if any

3 · SET A COMFORTABLE BUDGET

Your monthly payment is more than the loan. Plan for each piece:

Principal & interest	The loan itself
Property taxes	Paid monthly into escrow, billed by the county or city
Homeowner's insurance	Required by your lender
Mortgage insurance	May apply with a smaller down payment
HOA dues	If the neighborhood has an association
Maintenance	Set aside money for repairs and upkeep

Try the mortgage calculator at tianawinter.com/buy to estimate your monthly payment.

4 · CHOOSE YOUR AGENT

Before touring homes, you'll sign a written buyer agreement that spells out how I work for you and how I'm paid. It's a good moment to ask any question you have about the process. I'm happy to walk you through every line.

TOUR TO CLOSING DAY

5 · SEARCH & TOUR

I'll set you up with new-listing alerts and we'll tour the best matches. Take notes and photos, and trust your gut about how a home feels. Think about the drive, the neighbors and the light at different times of day, not just the kitchen.

6 · MAKE AN OFFER

A strong offer is about more than price. We'll look at recent comparable sales to set the number, then work through the terms:

- **Earnest money:** a good-faith deposit that goes toward your purchase.
- **Contingencies:** your protections, such as inspection, financing and appraisal.
- **Closing date and possession:** timing that works for you and the seller.
- **Requests:** repairs, credits, or items that stay with the home.

7 · INSPECT & APPRAISE

A professional inspection shows you the home's true condition. We'll review the report together and decide whether to request repairs, ask for a credit, or move on. Your lender orders an appraisal to confirm the home's value supports the loan.

8 · CLOSE & MOVE IN

In the final stretch your lender finishes underwriting, you review your closing disclosure, and we do a final walkthrough. At closing you sign, pay your closing costs and down payment, and receive the keys.

CLOSING DAY CHECKLIST

- ☐ Government photo ID
- ☐ Proof of funds, as directed
- ☐ Homeowner's insurance in place
- ☐ Utilities set up in your name
- ☐ Final walkthrough completed
- ☐ Change of address filed

Closing costs vary by loan and home, and often run a few percent of the purchase price. Your lender provides an estimate early in the process.

QUESTIONS WORTH ASKING

ABOUT THE HOME

- How old are the roof, HVAC and water heater?
- What's the average utility cost?
- Any past water, foundation or pest issues?
- What's included in the sale?
- Are there HOA fees or rules?

ABOUT THE NEIGHBORHOOD

- How long do homes here usually take to sell?
- What are the commute times at rush hour?
- What are nearby schools, parks and shops like?
- Is the home in a flood zone?
- Are any big changes or projects planned nearby?

CHOOSING YOUR PART OF TOWN

The Knoxville area offers a very different feel from one neighborhood to the next, from the walkable energy of Downtown and the river-and-trails lifestyle of South Knoxville to the established communities of West Knoxville, Farragut and Hardin Valley, and the small-town pace of Maryville, Blount County, Oak Ridge and Sevierville. Tell me how you want to live, and I'll point you to the areas that fit.

QUICK GLOSSARY

Pre-approval	A lender's written estimate of what you can borrow
Earnest money	A deposit that shows you're serious about the offer
Contingency	A condition that must be met for the sale to go forward
Appraisal	An independent opinion of the home's value
Escrow	A neutral account holding funds and documents until closing
Closing costs	Fees paid at closing for the loan, title and recording

READY WHEN YOU ARE

LET'S FIND YOUR HOME

Have questions, or ready to start? Book a time that works for you, and we'll map out your plan together.

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